

Crucifixion: The Word Decent People Did Not Say

In polite Roman society the cross was an obscenity, not a symbol. The first Christians preached it anyway.

THE WORD

The Unspeakable Word

Martin Hengel's short book *Crucifixion* gathered the ancient evidence and let it speak, and what it says is brutal. Crucifixion was the punishment Rome reserved for slaves, bandits, and rebels, the lowest deaths for the lowest people. Romans called it the slave's punishment. It was designed not merely to kill but to degrade, naked, public, slow, the body left where the city could see it.

Polite society handled the subject by not handling it. Cicero, defending a Roman citizen, argued that the very word cross should be far removed not only from the body of a Roman citizen but from his thoughts, his eyes, and his ears. That is not squeamishness about violence. Romans enjoyed violence at the arena. It is the verdict of a culture that the cross was shameful past the point of mention.

We wear the word on jewelry. We name churches after it. Twenty centuries of devotion have sanded it smooth. The New Testament was written before the smoothing, by people who used the obscenity on purpose.

THE CULTURE

A World Built on Honor

To feel the offense, you need the social physics of the first century. David deSilva and others describe it as an honor culture. A person's standing was not a private matter of self-esteem. It was a public account, opened at birth, adjusted constantly by the watching community. Honor came from ancestry, wealth, office, education, and from victories in the endless small contests of public life. Shame was not a feeling. It was a location, the bottom of the ladder, visible to everyone.

In such a world, boasting was not bad manners. It was maintenance. Inscriptions paraded titles.

Benefactors funded buildings to carry their names. Orators trained for years to win the crowd, and the crowd kept score.

The crucified man was this system's absolute zero. He had no honor left to lose, and his shame splashed onto everyone associated with him. Family, friends, followers. That is the world in which a small movement began announcing that the most important person in the universe had died on a cross, and that they were not ashamed of it. The claim was not just false to their neighbors. It was grammatically backward, like boasting of bankruptcy.

THE SCANDAL

We Preach Christ Crucified

Paul knew exactly how the message sounded. We preach Christ crucified, he told the Corinthians, a stumbling block to Jews and folly to Gentiles. He was not being modest. He was reporting market response. Jews knew the Scripture that a hanged man is cursed by God, which made a crucified Messiah a contradiction in terms. Greeks heard a claim that wisdom and power had appeared in a slave's death, which was not a hard argument to lose. It was no argument at all.

The mockery survives in plaster. Sometime around the third century, someone scratched a cartoon on a wall in Rome, a figure with a donkey's head hanging on a cross, a young man raising his hand toward it, and a caption. Alexamenos worships his god. That graffito is among our earliest images of the crucifixion, and it is a joke at a believer's expense.

Paul's response was not to soften the cross but to centralize it. Far be it from me to boast except in the cross. In a culture of competitive honor, he located his entire status in the most shameful object the culture possessed. Either that is derangement or the value system of the world had been judged. The first century saw the choice clearly. We have mostly arranged not to.

THE RESURRECTION

Athens Laughed at the Wrong Part

There is a second offense, and Acts 17 records it. When Paul preached in Athens, the educated audience stayed with him through creation, providence, even repentance. They broke at the resurrection of the dead. Some mocked. The reaction was not ignorance. It was education.

Greek thought, in its dominant streams, held that the soul was the true person and the body its temporary container, or worse, its prison. Death freed you. The idea that a corpse would be raised and glorified was not a comfort in that world. It was a regression, like being sentenced back to jail after release. Aeschylus had staged the point on the Areopagus itself centuries before. In his play, the god Apollo declares that once a man dies and the dust drinks his blood, there is no rising again. The word he uses is anastasis. Paul stood in that very place and announced anastasis as fact.

N. T. Wright has shown at length that the pagan world knew exactly what resurrection meant and denied that it happened. The first Christians were not reaching for a metaphor of hope. They were asserting an event their entire culture ruled impossible, about a man their entire culture ruled shameful, and they would not trade either claim for respectability.

THE WEIGHT

What Remains

Context here does one simple thing. It restores the cost. The cross was not a religious symbol that early Christians decorated with meaning. It was the meanest fact in their world, and they put it at the center because that is where God had put it. The resurrection was not a soft word for survival. It was a hard word for bodies, and it embarrassed every educated room it entered.

Knowing this does not make us better readers than our neighbors, and it gives us no one to look down on. The Corinthians who craved status are not strangers to me. I check the numbers. I read the room. I prefer the parts of the faith that cost nothing socially, and I am quieter about the parts that do. The first century is not behind us. It is the water we swim in, with better marketing.

So the old sentence still stands at the door of the faith, asking the same admission fee it asked in Corinth. We preach Christ crucified. The world has never stopped finding that foolish. The question the text leaves on the table is not whether we can explain the scandal. It is whether we still have one.

KEY TEXTS

1 Corinthians 1:22-25

Acts 17:31-32

Galatians 6:14

SOURCES

Crucifixion in the Ancient World and the Folly of the Message of the Cross — Martin Hengel

The Resurrection of the Son of God — N. T. Wright

Honor, Patronage, Kinship and Purity — David A. deSilva